

Standard Operating Procedure

High-Risk and LASA Medication Storage

«Hospital Name» — Supports MOM.3.c, MOM.3.d, MOM.3.e (Stop-Work), MOM.3.f, MOM.3.g

SOP No.	[Hospital to define]	Version	1.0
Effective Date		Review Frequency	Annual, or on change
Prepared By	Quality Coordinator Name: _____ Signature: _____		
Approved By	Medical Superintendent Name: _____ Signature: _____		

1. Purpose

This SOP describes how «Hospital Name» identifies, stores, and separates high-risk and LASA (look-alike, sound-alike) medications so a storage or labelling mix-up never reaches a patient.

2. Scope

Applies to the pharmacy and every clinical area that stores medication.

3. Responsibility

Chief Pharmacist: maintains the high-risk and LASA lists, and confirms physical separation is in place.

Ward/Unit In-Charge: confirms separation is maintained in their own area between pharmacy updates.

4. Procedure

4.1 High-risk medication list and storage

1. Maintain a defined, periodically updated high-risk medication list, posted in the pharmacy and every clinical area where high-risk medications are stored.

2. Store high-risk medications in predetermined, clinically justified locations with a safeguard against inadvertent administration — an auxiliary warning label, a double-lock, or an equivalent measure.

4.2 What counts as a LASA pair, and examples

A LASA pair is two medications whose names look similar when written (look-alike) or sound similar when spoken (sound-alike), creating a real risk that one is picked, prescribed, or dispensed in place of the other. Some pairs are both. Examples published by the Institute for Safe Medication Practices (ISMP) include:

- hydrALAZINE and hydroXYzine — sound-alike; one is a blood-pressure medication, the other an antihistamine/sedative.
- amILORIDE and amLODIPine — look-alike; a potassium-sparing diuretic confused with a calcium-channel blocker.
- DOPamine and DOBUTamine — sound-alike and look-alike; both are cardiac infusions with very different dosing, making this pair especially dangerous in an ICU or emergency setting.
- amiodarone and amantadine — sound-alike; an antiarrhythmic confused with an antiviral/antiparkinsonian agent.

These four are illustrations, not the hospital's actual list — pharmacy staff cross-check the full current ISMP List of Confused Drug Names (Section 9 reference) against «Hospital Name»'s own formulary to build and maintain the working list for this hospital.

4.3 Identifying LASA pairs specific to this hospital

1. The Chief Pharmacist cross-checks every item on the current formulary against the ISMP List of Confused Drug Names at least once a year, and whenever a new medication is added to the formulary.
2. Where two formulary medications are not on the ISMP list but share a similar spelling, pronunciation, packaging appearance, or storage location, add the pair to the hospital's own list — the ISMP list is a starting point, not a ceiling.
3. Give particular attention to medications stored near each other alphabetically or by drug class, since proximity increases risk even for names that are only moderately similar.

4.4 Separation and labelling

1. Physically separate every listed LASA pair in the pharmacy and in every patient care area where either drug is stored — never store them on adjacent shelves or bins.
2. Use Tall Man lettering (capitalising the differing letters, e.g. hydrALAZINE / hydrOXYzine) on LASA medication labels and storage bins wherever practicable, following the ISMP-recommended pattern for that pair.

4.5 Emergency medication stock

1. Maintain the defined emergency-medication list, uniformly stored and kept free of other drugs.
2. Check emergency stock at least daily — or, for sealed carts, after each use or once a month — and replenish immediately after use.

5. Stop-Work Authority

Do not store a listed LASA pair or different concentration of the same drug on the same shelf, bin, or drawer — physical separation is mandatory, every time, in every area.

Any staff member who finds a LASA pair stored together corrects it immediately and reports it the same shift — this is never treated as a disciplinary matter.

6. Records

Supported by Records 4 through 7 of the MOM.3 Required Records pack: High-Risk Medication List, High-Risk Storage Safeguard Record, LASA Medication List, and LASA Physical Separation Audit.

7. Related Documents

- Policy on Storage and Availability of Medications (HCO/MOM/POL/03) — MOM.3 policy, Section 5.5 (LASA identification and separation)

8. Review

Reviewed annually, and immediately after any LASA-related near miss or error.

9. References

- Institute for Safe Medication Practices (ISMP). (n.d.). List of Confused Drug Names. <https://home.ecri.org/blogs/ismp-resources/list-of-confused-drug-names> — the full current list of LASA pairs and recommended Tall Man lettering; the examples in Section 4.2 are drawn directly from it.

- Institute for Safe Medication Practices (ISMP). (2024). List of High-Alert Medications in Acute Care Settings. <https://home.ecri.org/blogs/ismpr-resources/high-alert-medications-in-acute-care-settings> — the reference list of medications requiring structural safeguards beyond ordinary vigilance.